

Even du Bois-Reymond was wrong. We are not even good at understanding the unknowable. Consider the statements we make about things that we will never come to know—we confidently underestimate what knowledge we may acquire in the future. Auguste Comte, the founder of the school of positivism, which is (unfairly) accused of aiming at the scientization of everything in sight, declared that mankind would forever remain ignorant of the chemical composition of the fixed stars. But, as Charles Sanders Peirce reported, “The ink was scarcely dry upon the printed page before the spectroscope was discovered and that which he had deemed absolutely unknowable was well on the way of getting ascertained.” Ironically, Comte’s other projections, concerning what we would come to learn about the workings of society, were grossly—and dangerously—overstated. He assumed that society was like a clock that would yield its secrets to us.

I’ll summarize my argument here: Prediction requires knowing about technologies that will be discovered in the future. But that very knowledge would almost automatically allow us to start developing those technologies right away. Ergo, we do not know what we will know.

Some might say that the argument, as phrased, seems obvious, that we always think that we have reached definitive knowledge but don’t notice that those past societies we laugh at also thought the same way. My argument is trivial, so why don’t we take it into account? The answer lies in a pathology of human nature. Remember the psychological discussions on asymmetries in the perception of skills in the previous chapter? We see flaws in others and not in ourselves. Once again we seem to be wonderful at self-deceit machines.



Monsieur le professeur Henri Poincaré. Somehow they stopped making this kind of thinker. *Courtesy of Université Nancy-2.*

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Henri Poincaré, in spite of his fame, is regularly considered to be an undervalued scientific thinker, given that it took close to a century for some of